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Sourdough Pizza Crust

★★★★★

By Traci (https://vanillaandbean.com/author/rtyorkcomcast-net/) · Jump to Recipe

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Step up your pizza game by making sourdough pizza dough! With simple ingredients and a little patience, you'll be rewarded with flavorful and chewy homemade pizza. I'm sharing several flour options so you can customize this sourdough pizza crust and use the flour you have on hand! This recipe is vegetarian and vegan friendly.

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A Weekend Tradition

Are you ready for a game changer in homemade pizza? Sourdough pizza is it! Flavorful, chewy, slightly crispy and so satisfying to make, sourdough pizza is something we look forward every weekend.

Making from scratch pizza really doesn't require that much hands on time. You'll think about it more than the time it actually takes to make it. And although this recipe looks like there is SO much to the process, once you get the routine down, you'll discover how simple making sourdough pizza dough really is.

Baker's Example Schedule for Pizza Dough:

- ***Thursday Night:*** *Mix the Dough – Ferment Overnight at Room Temperature*
- ***Friday Morning:*** *Shape the Dough – Pop it in the Refrigerator to Start Proofing*
- ***Friday Afternoon:*** *Pull the Sourdough Pizza Dough From the Refrigerator – Finish Proofing at Room Temperature for about 2-3 Hours.*
- ***Friday Night:*** *Shape and Bake!*

In this recipe, I'm sharing my tips, pizza making tools, a few different flour varieties to choose from and my favorite toppings. So get ready! Let's make homemade sourdough pizza!

Need a sourdough starter? Follow my DIY Sourdough Starter (https://vanillaandbean.com/sourdough-starter/) recipe.

The Start of Something Delicious

For this sourdough pizza dough recipe, start with five simple ingredients and a mixing bowl. Here's what you'll need:

- *Sourdough Starter – fed, doubled in size, ripe, and bubbly. Try my DIY Sourdough Starter (https://vanillaandbean.com/sourdough-starter/) to make one.*
- *Water – I use tap, but if you like, you can use filtered.*
- *Olive Oil – use a full bodied olive oil here for flavor. It tenderizes the dough!*
- *Flour – I like a mix of whole wheat and bread flour, but you can also use all, all purpose or all bread flour.*
- *Fine Sea Salt*

You'll mix the starter with water, then add the olive oil, using a fork to combine. Next, add the flour.

Mix the Dough

After the flour is added, use a fork to incorporate the ingredients. The pizza dough will be shaggy at first, and it'll seem dry. Switch to kneading with your hand, using your fingers like claws to knead until there are no dry bits left. The dough will feel stiff and sticky at this point.

Scrape the sourdough pizza dough off your fingers. Cover the bowl with a damp tea towel or bowl bonnet and allow to rest for 30 minutes.

Fold the Dough

Once the initial rest is done, fold the dough. This term simply means to take a portion of your dough, gently stretch it and press it down towards the center of the dough. Repeat this process until you work all the way around the dough. Notice how the dough changes from when you first kneaded it. It should be softer, not as messy and more playable, although still sticky.

At this point you can cover your dough with a damp tea towel and leave it to bulk ferment or you can do up to two more folds over the next hour. Performing folds builds strength and structure and improves the overall quality of your dough. Do whatever fits your schedule. You'll still have a fabulous sourdough pizza either way!

Bulk Fermentation (first rise)

This step shouldn't be rushed, because this is when most of the flavor development happens.

TIME = FLAVOR

At this point the dough is rested at room temperature ***until it doubles in size, is jiggly and no longer feels dense****. At 70F (21C), this will take anywhere from 8-10 hours. In my cooler kitchen, 65-68F (18-20C), it takes upwards of 12-14 hours. Use this time and temperature as a guide and not a determining factor for when the dough is ready. It's ready when it's ready.*

Shape – Rest – Shape

Once the dough has doubled in size, it's time to shape the dough. First, you'll divide dough into equal pieces. Then shape each piece into a rough round by folding each side to the middle, then the top and bottom. Flip the dough over and allow it to rest for about 10 minutes.

This is a good time to prepare your proofing containers. I like to use 4 C (950mL) lidded glass bowls for this. It helps the dough hold it's shape and they're reusable. Zip top or reusable food storage bags can be used as well. Simply brush the vessel with olive oil to prevent sticking.

After the rest, you'll shape the dough into dough balls, making sure the skin/surface is taught and transfer the dough to its proofing container.

Time to Freeze the Dough (optional): *If you opt to freeze your dough balls, this is the time to do it. Freeze them in zip top bags or in their glass storage containers. When ready to use, thaw them out overnight in the refrigerator, then carry on with proofing the following day. Note that the dough doesn't quite bake up as beautifully as fresh dough, but freezing is an option.*

Proof Two Ways (second rise)

After shaping the dough, there are several ways to proof the dough, depending on your schedule:

***Refrigerator**: After shaping the dough, you can pop it in the fridge for up to two days. It will continue to rise in the refrigerator, just at a slower rate. You'll need to pull the dough from the fridge about two to three hours before you're ready to make pizza so it can finish rising and/or warm up to room temperature (this at a room temperature of 65-68F). Trying to shape pizza with cold dough is frustrating, so make sure you give it time to warm up. This is the method I prefer because it works for my schedule.*

The first photo above shows the dough just pulled from the fridge after a six hour refrigerator proof. The second image (the same dough), shows the dough after continuing to proof at room temperature for about two and a half hours. The image on the right is fluffy and slightly bubbly – ready for making pizza!

***Room Temperature:** If you're ready to make pizza sooner than later, you can skip refrigeration and proof the dough at room temperature for about one and a half hours (this at a room temperature of 65-68F) right after shaping the dough. The warmer the kitchen, the quicker the rise. Keep an eye on it.*

***When is it Ready?** The dough is ready to make pizza when it's risen between over one and a half times in size and just under doubling in size, is puffy and springy to the touch (it's pretty forgiving – just make sure it's at room temp).*

***In a Hurry?** I usually don't advocate for speeding up sourdough, but this is a time where you can. If you want the proof to go a little more quickly, pop the dough balls in the proofing vessel in a turned off oven with the light on. This will speed the process a bit.*

Let's Make Pizza!

Preparing the Oven*: Place an oven rack on the second setting from the top. If making a second pizza, set another rack two positions below the top one. You can easily bake two pizzas at a time. Place an upside down sheet pan and/or a pizza stone on a rack, one each if baking two pizzas.*

Preheat the Oven & Pan/Stone*: to 550F preferably, or 500F if that is as hot as your oven gets. You'll want to preheat for at least 45 minutes.*

Just before getting ready to shape the dough, and while your oven is preheating, gather and prepare the ingredients, chopping small or slicing thin. When making pizza, less is more for a crisper bottom crust (but don't look at my pizza below – I pile on the toppings!). You can opt to saute the veggies before putting them on the pizza if you like. I go with raw.

Shape the Pizza Dough: *Don't be shy with the flour here! Gently nudge the sourdough pizza dough out of the proofing vessel and onto a floured surface trying to keep it in a round as best you can. Flour the top and edges generously.*

Dimple the center of the dough using your finger tips gently pressing down to the surface of the board (think focaccia). Avoid the outer 1/4" of the dough ball – this is your crust edge. Pick the dough up and place it on the backs of your fisted and floured hands gently pulling and stretching the dough into a disc. Place back down on your floured surface. Is the shape how you like it? If not give it a few stretches again using the back of your hands until it's rounded. The pizza should measure about 11" (28cm).

If you feel the dough is tight, place it on the board and let it rest for about 5 minutes before you attempt shaping again. It will relax as it sets.

Add the Toppings

Place the shaped dough on a piece of parchment paper. The parchment will be used to transfer the dough onto the preheated pizza stone or sheet pan. ***Note that parchment paper is generally rated for use under 500F.*** *So at 550F, with any overhang, the paper will char and become brittle. Cooks Illustrated (https://www.cooksillustrated.com/how_tos/5858-can-you-heat-parchment-paper-higher-than-manufacturers-recommend) has more on this.*

The Sauce*: Spread a thin layer of sauce on the pizza. You can opt for a rich and thick homemade red pizza sauce (https://vanillaandbean.com/homemade-pizza-sauce/) or your favorite marinara right from the jar, your favorite basil pesto (https://vanillaandbean.com/lemon-basil-pesto/) or garlic scape pesto (https://vanillaandbean.com/garlic-scape-pesto/) or a white sauce. A thin layer will bring out the best potential for the bottom to crisp up.*

***The Veggies**: Less is more when it comes to pizza making depending on how crisp/chewy you prefer the bottom crust to be. I don't mind if the bottom crust is a bit soft so I pile on the toppings. If you prefer a crisper crust, go light on the sauce and toppings. You can also saute the veggies to bring out even more flavor before topping your pizza. For a home run, try caramelized onions!*

For greens like spinach, keep it under the cheese so it doesn't burn.

***The Cheese:** A thin layer of cheese on top of the sauce is a delicious way to add layers to the pizza. I like fresh shredded parmesan. Then, after the veggies and for the top, try at three or more variety of cheeses. My favorites shredded Italian blend, shredded mozzarella, fresh mozzarella and/or feta.*

***Top the Cheese:** Before baking, top the pizza with olives and dried Italian herbs. Fresh basil can go on top after baking.*

Bake the Pizza

Once you're ready to bake, transfer the pizza to a pizza peel or back of a sheet pan. Trim the parchment so that it's just flush with the pizza dough leaving a bit of overhang to use as a handle if needed. Slide the pizza off the peel or back of a sheet pan and onto the preheated stone/pan. Be careful, the oven is HOT!

Bake the pizza for about 7-9 minutes, or until the cheese is melty and the crust is golden with some charring. It bakes fast, so keep an eye on it! Use the peel or back of a sheet pan to remove the pizza from the oven and transfer to a cutting board.

Allow the pizza to rest for about five minutes before cutting into it. Your sourdough pizza is ready!

Related: *Gluten Free? Give my easy Gluten Free Pizza Crust (https://vanillaandbean.com/gluten-free-pizza-crust/) a go!*

A Few Recipe Notes

- ***Note that parchment paper is generally rated for use under 500F.*** *So at 550F, with any overhang, beyond the pizza dough, the paper will char and become brittle. Cooks Illustrated (https://www.cooksillustrated.com/how_tos/5858-can-you-heat-parchment-paper-higher-than-manufacturers-recommend) has more on this.*
- *Use the times mentioned in the recipe as a guide rather than a determining factor for when the sourdough pizza dough is done fermenting and proofing. Ambient temperature and how active your starter is will determine when the dough is ready.*

It's ready when it's ready.

- *I love the **flexibility** of this recipe.*
  - *As written, the recipe produces a soft, chewy crust with crispy edges. For a crisper crust, you can reduce the water just a bit. A few Tablespoons makes a difference. Play with the hydration until you find your pizza bliss!*
  - *Because moisture content can vary from one bag of flour to another and also due to humidity variations in the environment, feel free to adjust the water content one teaspoon at a time if the dough feels too dry during mixing.*
  - *Use all, all purpose or bread flour or mix in a bit of whole wheat flour for a more rustic dough with a bit of a nutty flavor. For all purpose, you'll reduce the water a bit because it's not as thirsty as bread flour.*
- ***Freezer Friendly?** Yes please! After shaping the dough and putting it into the proofing vessel, transfer it to the freezer. Thaw in the refrigerator over night and proof as written in the recipe. I've noticed a previously frozen pizza dough doesn't rise as high or have quite the same texture as fresh dough, but it is an option nevertheless.*

Sourdough Pizza Making Tools (these are affiliate links):

- *Pizza Peel (https://www.amazon.com/gp/product/B07C3Z9297/ref=as_li_ss_tl?pf_rd_m=ATVPDKIKX0DER&pf_rd_s=merchandised-search-4&pf_rd_r=W4D7A9NFNA4H55018BED&pf_rd_r=W4D7A9NFNA4H55018BED&pf_rd_t=101&pf_rd_p=f5b42b97-13fc-532c-8728-b96ee018a427&pf_rd_p=f5b42b97-13fc-532c-8728-b96ee018a427&pf_rd_i=383851011&linkCode=ll1&tag=vanandbea-20&linkId=f4eafaed5a9d11c53cb875cb2eb05897&language=en_US)*
- *Pizza Baking Stone (https://www.amazon.com/Pizza-Stone-Baking-Rectangular-Perfect/dp/B01GMYARYG/ref=as_li_ss_tl?s=home-garden&ie=UTF8&qid=1537984117&sr=1-19&keywords=pizza+stone&linkCode=ll1&tag=vanandbea-20&linkId=930d78719135b5694e74b7848029e120&language=en_US)*
- *Pyrex 4 Cup Bowls (https://www.amazon.com/Pyrex-Simply-Store-Glass-Container/dp/B004GHB9IU/ref=as_li_ss_tl?dchild=1&keywords=pyrex+4c+bowl+with+lid&qid=1587765358&s=home-garden&sr=1-27-spons&psc=1&spLa=ZW5jcnlwdGVkUXVhbGlmaWVyPUExQkFVMUZERUU1MlBNJmVuY3J5cHRlZElkPUEwNTE3MDc2OTFEWUg4T0tQWjNUJmVuY3J5cHRlZEFkSWQ9QTA5MDgzODAxM0ZaRFlQVFlUOUY0JndpZGdldE5hbWU9c3BfYnRmJmFjdGlvbj1jbGlja1JlZGlyZWN0JmRvTm90TG9nQ2xpY2s9dHJ1ZQ==&linkCode=ll1&tag=vanandbea-20&linkId=bc8be0b88056c818580bc19f55270fe9&language=en_US) – for proofing*
- *Aluminum Baking Pans (https://www.amazon.com/Nordic-Ware-Natural-Aluminum-Commercial/dp/B0049C2S32/ref=as_li_ss_tl?dchild=1&keywords=Baking+sheet+pan&qid=1587765488&s=home-garden&sr=1-2&th=1&linkCode=ll1&tag=vanandbea-20&linkId=4c6aa7823dba304755ed3bfc47fb9252&language=en_US)*
- *Parchment Paper (https://www.amazon.com/CARE-Certified-Parchment-Baking-Paper/dp/B001T6JTMY/ref=as_li_ss_tl?dchild=1&keywords=If+you+care+parchment+paper&qid=1587765450&s=home-garden&sr=1-1&linkCode=ll1&tag=vanandbea-20&linkId=53601ccdb77b97b1c49759c06809f004&language=en_US)*
- *Bench Scraper (https://www.amazon.com/OXO-Multi-purpose-Stainless-Scraper-Chopper/dp/B00004OCNJ/ref=as_li_ss_tl?s=home-garden&ie=UTF8&qid=1509564780&sr=1-1&keywords=oxo+bench+scraper&dpID=311FAYKN2DL&preST=_SX300_QL70_&dpSrc=srch&linkCode=ll1&tag=vanandbea-20&linkId=b35ac6a4ff1657ffcabdd5c32c57868d&language=en_US)*
- *Digital Scale (https://www.amazon.com/OXO-Stainless-Pull-Out-Display-11-Pound/dp/B000WJMTNA/ref=as_li_ss_tl?_encoding=UTF8&pd_rd_i=B000WJMTNA&pd_rd_r=PPK6BC131YZ3CJNS9XVD&pd_rd_w=bin4r&pd_rd_wg=mYZ5b&psc=1&refRID=PPK6BC131YZ3CJNS9XVD&dpID=41et8e7yOVL&preST=_SX300_QL70_&dpSrc=detail&linkCode=ll1&tag=vanandbea-20&linkId=458650f5ed3ba0e0e3e0a37e4aedc60a&language=en_US)*

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*I **made a video** of my pizza making process on Instagram! Link to my Instagram page (https://www.instagram.com/vanillaandbean/?hl=en)and look for SD Pizza! in highlights!*

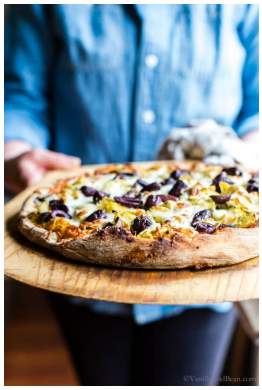
***RELATED**: Use your starter in Sourdough (https://vanillaandbean.com/maple-oat-sourdough-sandwich-bread/) Maple Oat Sandwich Bread (https://vanillaandbean.com/maple-oat-sourdough-sandwich-bread/), Seedy Multigrain, (https://vanillaandbean.com/multigrain-sourdough-bread/) Sourdough Dinner Rolls (https://vanillaandbean.com/soft-sourdough-rolls/) and, if you have discard, give my Easy Biscuits Recipe (https://vanillaandbean.com/sourdough-biscuits/) a go.*

the recipe

Sourdough Pizza Crust

★★★★★

Prep Time:	45 minutes
Cook Time:	9 minutes
Bulk Ferment + Proof:	11 hours
Total Time:	11 hours 54 minutes
Servings:	1 11" Pizza
Calories:	2131kcal
Author:	Traci York | Vanilla And Bean



Print Recipe (https://vanillaandbean.com/wprm_print/recipe/38298)

**Advance Prep Required - You'll Need a Sourdough Starter (https://vanillaandbean.com/sourdough-starter/) ** There is some planning involved in this recipe with both timing and equipment. Read the recipe all the way through prior to starting.

Step up your pizza game by making it sourdough! With simple ingredients and a little patience, you'll be rewarded with flavorful and chewy homemade pizza. I'm sharing several flour options so you can make this sourdough pizza crust with the flour you have on hand! This recipe is vegetarian and vegan friendly.

Time above for fermenting and proofing can vary depending on ambient temperature and starter activity. Use the time as a guide and not a determining factor for when the dough is ready. This is the nature of sourdough. Prep time indicated does not include any rest time.

Each pizza yields 8 slices

Example Bakers Schedule

Thursday Night: Mix the Dough - Ferment Overnight at Room Temperature

Friday Morning: Shape the Dough - Pop it in the Refrigerator to Start Proofing

Friday Afternoon: Pull the Dough From the Refrigerator - Finish Proofing at Room Temperature for about 2-3 Hours.

Friday Night: Shape and Bake!

Ingredients

For Four 11" Pizzas:

- 1/4 C (50g) Sourdough Starter (https://vanillaandbean.com/sourdough-starter/) bubbly, doubled in size, active starter
- 1 1/3 C + 2 Tbs (350g) Water 80f (26c) **See note on Hydration
- 3 Tbs (30g) Extra Virgin Olive Oil (https://www.amazon.com/California-Olive-Ranch-Oil-16-9/dp/B00NQ3ZVD4/ref=as_li_ss_tl?dchild=1&keywords=California+Olive+Ranch,+Everyday+Extra+Virgin+Olive+Oil&qid=1589584676&s=grocery&sr=1-16&th=1&linkCode=ll1&tag=vanandbea-20&linkId=336d882a4f08eca515eaec105ba5e813&language=en_US) plus more for proofing vessels
- 3 C (410g) Bread Flour (https://www.amazon.com/King-Arthur-Flour-Organic-Unbleached/dp/B00P6ERTS6/ref=as_li_ss_tl?ref_=fsclp_pl_dp_4&linkCode=ll1&tag=vanandbea-20&linkId=133b2379af933b297f22cf0e3c5a9a28&language=en_US)
- 1/2 C + 1 Tbs (100g) Whole Wheat Flour (https://www.amazon.com/King-Arthur-Flour-Premium-Whole/dp/B00P6ER2U6/ref=as_li_ss_tl?ref_=fsclp_pl_dp_2&linkCode=ll1&tag=vanandbea-20&linkId=739fd0d7dd9993ed7015759565519d2a&language=en_US) or Whole Wheat Bread Flour *see note for flour subs
- 1 1/2 tsp Fine Sea Salt

For Two 11" Pizzas:

- 2 Tbs (25g) Sourdough Starter (https://vanillaandbean.com/sourdough-starter/) bubbly, doubled in size, active starter
- 3/4 C (175g) Water 80f (26c) **See note on Hydration
- 1 1/2 Tbs Extra Virgin Olive Oil (https://www.amazon.com/California-Olive-Ranch-Oil-16-9/dp/B00NQ3ZVD4/ref=as_li_ss_tl?dchild=1&keywords=California+Olive+Ranch,+Everyday+Extra+Virgin+Olive+Oil&qid=1589584676&s=grocery&sr=1-16&th=1&linkCode=ll1&tag=vanandbea-20&linkId=336d882a4f08eca515eaec105ba5e813&language=en_US) plus more for proofing vessels
- 1 1/2 C (205g) Bread Flour (https://www.amazon.com/King-Arthur-Flour-Organic-Unbleached/dp/B00P6ERTS6/ref=as_li_ss_tl?ref_=fsclp_pl_dp_4&linkCode=ll1&tag=vanandbea-20&linkId=133b2379af933b297f22cf0e3c5a9a28&language=en_US)
- 1/4 C + 2 tsp (50g) Whole Wheat Flour (https://www.amazon.com/King-Arthur-Flour-Premium-Whole/dp/B00P6ER2U6/ref=as_li_ss_tl?ref_=fsclp_pl_dp_2&linkCode=ll1&tag=vanandbea-20&linkId=739fd0d7dd9993ed7015759565519d2a&language=en_US) or Whole Wheat Bread Flour *see note for flour subs
- 3/4 tsp Fine Sea Salt

Instructions

Mix the Dough:

1.

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   In a large mixing bowl for 4 pizzas (or a medium bowl for 2), add the starter, water and olive oil. Mix with a fork, then add the flour and salt. Mix with a fork until a shaggy dough forms. The dough will seem dry. Switch to kneading with your hand, using your fingers like claws and by folding the dough to knead until there are no dry bits left. The dough will feel stiff and sticky at this point
2. Use the fork to scrape the dough off your fingers. Cover the bowl with a damp tea towel and allow to rest for 30 minutes at room temperature.

Fold the Dough:

1. Once the initial rest is done, fold the dough. This simply means to take a portion of your dough, while still in the bowl, gently stretch it and press it down towards the center of the dough. Repeat this process until you work all the way around the dough.

   Notice how the dough changes from when you first kneaded it. It should be softer, not as *messy* and more playable, although still sticky. TIP: Moisten your fingers with water before handling the dough - it won't stick as much.

   At this point you can leave the dough to bulk ferment at room temperature OR you can do up to two more folds over the next hour at 30 minute intervals. Performing folds builds strength and structure and improves the overall quality of your dough. Do whatever fits your schedule. You'll still have a fabulous pizza either way!

Bulk Fermentation (first rise):

1. Cover the bowl with two damp tea towels (doubling up keeps the dough from drying out). Rest the dough at room temperature **until it doubles in size, is jiggly and no longer looks dense**.

   At 70F (21C), this will take anywhere from 8-10 hours. In my cooler kitchen, 65-68F (18-20C), it takes upwards of 12-14 hours to double in size. Use this time and temperature as a guide and not a determining factor for when the dough is ready. It's ready when it's ready.

Initial Shaping:

1. Once the dough has doubled in size, it's time to shape the dough.

   Coax the dough out of the bowl and onto a floured surface. Divide the dough into equal pieces - four for four 11" pizzas or two for two 11" pizzas. Then shape each piece into a rough round by folding each side to the middle, then the top and bottom. Flip the dough over and allow it to rest for about 10 minutes (set a timer).

   This is a good time to prepare your proofing vessels. I like to use a 4 C (950mL) lidded glass bowl for this - one for each ball. It helps the dough hold it's shape and they're reusable. Zip top or reusable food storage bags can be used as well. Simply brush the vessel throughly with olive oil to prevent sticking.

   After the bench rest, shape the dough into dough balls. This video shows us (https://www.google.com/search?q=how+to+shape+dough+balls+for+pizza&oq=how+to+shape+dough+balls+for+pizza&aqs=chrome..69i57j0l2.7583j0j7&sourceid=chrome&ie=UTF-8#kpvalbx=_822jXuLABJLV9APP2aj4BQ119)one method - start at 1:10 minutes. (https://www.google.com/search?q=how+to+shape+dough+balls+for+pizza&oq=how+to+shape+dough+balls+for+pizza&aqs=chrome..69i57j0l2.7583j0j7&sourceid=chrome&ie=UTF-8#kpvalbx=_822jXuLABJLV9APP2aj4BQ119)Make sure the skin/surface is taught, then transfer the dough to it's proofing container seam side down. Put a lid on the container or seal the bag.

   Time to Freeze the Dough (optional): If you opt to freeze your dough balls, this is the time to do it. Freeze them in zip top bags or in their glass storage containers. When ready to use, thaw them out overnight in the refrigerator, then carry on with proofing the following day. Note that the dough doesn't quite bake up as beautifully as fresh dough, but freezing is an option.

Proof the Dough (second rise):

1. After shaping the dough, there are two ways to proof the dough, depending on your schedule.

   A. Refrigerator:

   After shaping the dough, you can pop it in the fridge for up to two days. Keep in mind that it's still rising as it sets in the fridge, but at a much slower rate. Set the dough in its proofing vessel on the bottom shelf if you can.

   Two to three hours before you're ready to make pizza, pull the dough out of the refrigerator and set at room temperature so the dough can finish rising and/or warm up to room temperature (this at a kitchen temperature of 65F). Trying to shape pizza with cold dough is frustrating and results in a lackluster crust, so make sure you give it time to warm up to room temperature and finish rising.

   B. Room Temperature:

   Right after shaping the dough and you're If you're ready to make pizza, skip refrigeration and proof the dough at room temperature for about one and a half hours (this at a kitchen temperature of 65F). The warmer the kitchen, the quicker the rise. Keep an eye on it.

   When is the Dough Ready? **The dough is ready to make pizza when it's risen between over one and a half times in size and just under doubling in size, is puffy and springy to the touch (it's pretty forgiving - just make sure it's at room temp).**

   PRO TIP: In a Hurry? I usually don't advocate for speeding up sourdough, but this is a time where you can! If you want the proof to go a little more quickly, pop the dough balls in their proofing vessel, in the oven ***with the oven turned off and the light on***. This will speed the process a bit.

Let's Make Pizza!:

1. **Prepare the Oven**: Place an oven rack on the second setting from the top. If making a second pizza, set another rack two positions below the top one. You can easily bake two pizzas at a time. Place an upside down sheet pan and/or a pizza stone on a rack, one on each rack if baking two pizzas. If you proofed the dough in your turned off oven, remove the dough now.

   Preheat the Oven & Pan/Stone: to 550F. You'll want to preheat for at least 45 minutes.

2. Have a sheet of parchment paper ready for each pizza you're making. Also, have a pizza peel or sheet pan standing by to slide the shaped and topped dough on for transferring the unbaked pizza to the oven and onto preheated pan and/or baking stone.

   Prepare Ingredients: Just before getting ready to shape the final dough, gather and prepare all your ingredients, chopping small or slicing thin. When making pizza, less is more for a crisper bottom crust (I over top my pizza - so don't go by example if you want a

crisper bottom crust). You can opt to saute the veggies before putting them on the pizza if you like. I go with raw.

3. **Shape the Pizza Dough:**

   Don't be shy with the flour here! Gently nudge the dough out of the proofing vessel and onto a floured surface trying to keep it in a round as best you can. Flour the top and edges of the dough generously. If it's sticking to anything, sprinkle a bit more flour.

   Dimple the dough using your finger tips on both hands gently pressing down to the surface of the board (think focaccia) 4-5 times. Avoid the outer 1/4"- 1/2" of the dough - this is your crust edge.

   Pick the dough up and place it on the backs of your fisted and floured hands gently pulling and stretching the dough while moving your hands to transfer the points of contact with the dough. Shape into a disc shape taking care not to rip the dough. Place back down on your floured surface. Is the shape how you like it? If not give it a few stretches again using the back of your hands until you're happy with the shape. The dough should measure 11" (28cm). Don't worry if it's not perfectly round - a rectangle or amobea shape works too!

   If you feel the dough is tight, place it on the board and let it rest for about 5 minutes before you attempt shaping again. It will relax as it rests. If making two pizzas, shape them both, one after another.

   Transfer each pizza round to a piece of parchment paper and trim the edges of the parchment flush with the pizza dough, leaving just enough overhang to act as a handle.

   Note that parchment paper is generally rated for use under 500F. So at 550F, with any overhang, the paper will char and become brittle.

4. **Add the Toppings - less is more! (see a crispier option in the notes***):**

   The Sauce: Spread a thin layer of sauce on the pizza. You can opt for a red pizza sauce (https://vanillaandbean.com/homemade-pizza-sauce/), your favorite basil pesto (https://vanillaandbean.com/lemon-basil-pesto/) or garlic scape pesto (https://vanillaandbean.com/garlic-scape-pesto/) or a white sauce. A thin layer will bring out the best potential for the bottom crust to bake through.

   The Cheese: A limited scattering of cheese on top of the sauce is a delicious way to add layers to the pizza. I like fresh shredded parmesan. Then, after the veggies and for the top, try a variety (in a limited amount) of cheeses like an Italian blend, shredded mozzarella, fresh mozzarella and/or feta.

   The Veggies: Less is more when it comes to pizza toppings. I don't mind if the bottom crust is a bit soft so I pile on the toppings. If you prefer a crisper crust, go light on the sauce and toppings. My favorite pie includes mushrooms (raw), marinated artichokes (squeezed of its juices/oils) and Kalamata (drained throughly).

Bake the Pizza:

1. Working quickly (you don't want the raw dough with the toppings to hang out too long), transfer the pizza onto a pizza peel or the back of a sheet pan using the parchment as a handle if needed. Open the oven and pull out the rack with the preheated stone or pan. Slide the pizza onto the preheated pizza stone and/or pan using the parchment as a handle if needed. Be careful as the oven is HOT! Repeat with the second pizza if making two.

   Bake the assembled pizza(s) for 7-9 minutes **OR** until the dough is golden brown with some charring, the cheese has melted and sauce is bubbly. The pizza bakes fast at high heat, so keep an eye on it!

   Remove the pizza(s) from oven and allow to rest for five minutes. Cut into 8 equal pieces and enjoy!

Store Leftover Pizza:

1. Store pizza leftovers in a lidded container in the refrigerator for up to three days. Reheat at 350F for about 10 minutes.

Notes

Need a sourdough starter? Follow my DIY Sourdough Starter (https://vanillaandbean.com/sourdough-starter/) recipe.

***FLOUR SUBS:** For this recipe you can use all, all purpose 3 1/2 C (500g) or all bread flour 3 1/2 C + 1 T (500g) instead of incorporating whole wheat flour (these measurements are for four pizzas). Note that the dough is not as stretchy when using all purpose, and you'll need to reduce the water by a few tablespoons because it's not as thirsty as bread and/or whole wheat flour. If it seems too wet, add a tablespoon of flour. But, AP flour still makes a darn good pizza. With practice and experience, you'll gain an understanding for how the dough should *feel*.

****HYDRATION**: Flour can vary slightly in moisture content from bag to bag and brand to brand. Local humidity also plays a role in flour moisture. If the dough feels too dry when mixing, add a few teaspoons of water (one tsp at a time). Too wet? Add a sprinkle of flour (a little goes a long way!). As written, this recipe produces a soft, chewy crust with crispy edges. For a crisper crust, you can reduce the water just a bit. A Tablespoon or two makes a difference. Play with the hydration until you find your pizza bliss!

*****A CRISPIER OPTION - PAR BAKING:** To make the pizza crispier, you can par bake the crust for about four minutes before adding the toppings. Pull the par baked crust from the oven, then add the toppings and bake another 5ish minutes. Be sure to use the tines of a fork to dock the dough several times before baking taking care to leave about 1/2" of edge crust undocked prior to going in the oven. The crust will be extra crispy if you go this route!

In baking, weighing ingredients is important for an optimal outcome. If you feel you'll be baking regularly, I recommend investing in a digital kitchen scale (https://www.amazon.com/OXO-Stainless-Pull-Out-Display-11-Pound/dp/B000WJMTNA/ref=as_li_ss_tl?ie=UTF8&linkCode=ll1&tag=vanandbea-20&linkId=e622a25e6e943e6cc881aeb91cdda1bd&language=en_US).

Nutrition below is for crust only. Toppings are extra!

Nutrition is provided as a courtesy and is an estimate. If this information is important to you, please have it verified independently.
Serving: 1, 11" Pizza | Calories: 2131kcal | Carbohydrates: 379g | Protein: 64g | Fat: 39g | Saturated Fat: 6g | Sodium: 3517mg | Potassium: 773mg | Fiber: 21g | Sugar: 2g | Calcium: 106mg | Iron: 7mg

You Might Also Like:

Seeded Multigrain Gluten Free Sourdough Bread

(https://vanillaandbean.com/seeded-multigrain-gluten-free-sourdough-bread/)

Gluten Free Pizza Crust

(https://vanillaandbean.com/gluten-free-pizza-crust/)

Artichoke Chickpea Vegan "Crab" Cakes

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